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Coordinated Maximum Pressure Campaigns — An Illustrated Execution Framework

How Layered Friction, Reliability Degradation, and Escalation Guardrails Can Be Sequenced Under Existing Authorities

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Purpose:	Analytical illustration of how existing statutory authorities could be sequenced in a coordinated maximum pressure campaign. Offered as a drafting aid — modular sections may be adapted, modified, or discarded as practitioners require.
Why This Exists:	Desk officers and policy staff are often drowning in reactive drafting. External analysts sometimes have the luxury of time that desk officers don't — time to map authorities, flag recurring gaps, and illustrate a more deliberate rhythm. This paper attempts that service. It synthesizes open-source authorities and 2025–2026 enforcement patterns into a notional coordination model. Nothing here is sacred. Copy it, rewrite it, ignore sections entirely. If it saves anyone a few hours, it has done its job.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This paper illustrates how coordinated use of existing legal authorities — sequenced rather than episodic, evidence-gated rather than reactive, and calibrated against financial system stability indicators — can impose measurable and compounding costs on illicit state and non-state financial and logistics networks over a 24–60 month horizon.

What This Framework Can and Cannot Achieve

Can achieve (with sustained authorization, evidentiary sufficiency, allied synchronization, and disciplined escalation control):

- Revenue haircut and higher variance for targeted networks — through discounting pressure, insurance and finance friction, logistics cost inflation.
- Procurement degradation — spares, firmware, and service pipeline denial drives capability erosion more durably than financial pressure alone.
- Network fragmentation — intermediary exit, increased counterparty complexity, elevated state subsidy burden.

Cannot achieve (absent additional instruments of national power):

- Guaranteed dismantlement of nuclear programs or macroeconomic destabilization of peer economies. Sanctions architectures impose costs and increase variance; they do not deterministically collapse peer systems.
- Rapid or decisive outcomes. This framework is calibrated for controlled, compounding degradation over multi-year horizons — not coercive breakthrough.

Core Problem This Paper Addresses

Prior maximum pressure cycles have produced a consistent structural failure: tactical enforcement success combined with gradual erosion of monetary leverage, coalition cohesion, and systemic credibility. The mechanism is not insufficient designations — it is episodic, non-calendared enforcement that targets correctly assess as tolerable; escalation decisions made without evidence that prior actions are producing effects; and no guardrail preventing enforcement from inadvertently accelerating de-dollarization or coalition fracture.

This paper illustrates what addressing those gaps would look like operationally. It does not invent new doctrine. It formalizes coordination logic that OFAC, TFI, State INL, and DOJ AFMLS practitioners already use informally, and maps the authority architecture against which specific actions would be measured.

Five Structural Gaps Addressed

1. Designation latency: standard pipeline averages 45–120 days. Pre-staged packages eliminate this gap for threshold-triggered execution.
2. Sequential rather than simultaneous enforcement: financial and export control actions executed in series create adaptation windows. Simultaneous BIS/OFAC action closes these windows.
3. Episodic secondary sanctions: targets correctly calculate that infrequent enforcement is tolerable risk. Calendared, predictable cycles restore deterrence credibility.
4. No observability protocol: escalation decisions made without standardized telemetry that prior actions are producing network effects. Composite logistics reliability metrics provide the prerequisite evidentiary basis.
5. Coalition endurance deficit: absent structured remediation pathways and compliance incentives, enforcement partners calculate that non-participation costs less than participation. Structured incentive architecture manages this.

Grounding in 2025–2026 Enforcement Practice

This paper synthesizes patterns from actual recent enforcement cycles rather than constructing theory in isolation. Key anchoring examples are noted throughout:

- OFAC's July 2025 designation of 115+ Iranian shipping entities and the April 2025 maritime guidance on deceptive shipping practices illustrate the layered friction approach this paper formalizes.[1]
- Treasury's 2025–2026 focus on targeting reinsurance providers and classification societies in shadow-fleet advisories is the real-world basis for the reliability degradation targeting described in Section VI.[2]
- IMF COFER Q3 2025 data showing USD allocated reserves at approximately 56.92% provides the empirical baseline for the dollar reserve share guardrail trigger described in Section VII.[3]
- FATF's 2024–2025 typologies reports on evasion through crypto, professional enablers, and trade finance provide the evidentiary basis for the observability metrics in Section VIII.[4]

[1] OFAC Press Release, July 2025 (Iran shipping designations); OFAC Maritime Advisory on Deceptive Shipping Practices, April 2025. Available at ofac.treas.gov.

[2] U.S. Treasury / OFAC Shadow Fleet Advisories, 2024–2026 series. Available at home.treasury.gov.

[3] IMF COFER Database, Q3 2025. Available at data.imf.org. Note: actual operational thresholds would require classified baseline analysis.

[4] FATF Report on Trade-Based Money Laundering, 2024; FATF Guidance on Virtual Assets, 2025. Available at fatf-gafi.org.

I. STRATEGIC FRAMING — WHAT THIS APPROACH ASSUMES

Sustained maximum pressure in multipolar environments faces structural constraints that prior campaign designs have underweighted. This framework is built around those constraints, not despite them.

The Framework Assumes	The Framework Does Not Assume
Multipolar competition and major-power shielding persist	Regime collapse or coercive breakthrough outcomes
Closed-loop substitution systems may develop	Complete volume suppression of targeted networks
Coalition alignment requires active management and structured incentives	Allied partners maintain alignment without institutional support
Tactical enforcement success can coexist with monetary leverage erosion	Aggressive enforcement is cost-free to dollar centrality
Success = preserved leverage and controlled degradation over 24–60 months	Rapid or decisive outcomes against peer systems
Illustrative threshold bands require classified baseline validation	The specific bands in this paper are operationally precise

These constraints respond directly to observed failure modes. The 2018–2020 Iran maximum pressure cycle produced significant revenue reduction but also accelerated adaptation through CIPS growth, shadow fleet normalization, and crypto evasion infrastructure development — all of which are now more entrenched. The Russia sanctions response since 2022 has produced similar dynamics: genuine economic impact combined with structural momentum toward alternative settlement architectures.[5] The framework here is designed to impose costs while managing the guardrails that prior campaigns lacked.

[5] *See CNAS, 'Economic Statecraft in the Age of Sanctions Fatigue' (2025); Atlantic Council, 'Russia Sanctions at Year Three' (2025). Both available publicly.*

II. LEGAL AUTHORITY QUICK-REFERENCE

In practice, this is the quick-reference layer of the framework — the authority map a drafter would want nearby when writing a tasking memo or a decision package. Characterizations are analytical summaries; specific enforcement actions require independent agency legal review. All citations are public. Parameters are illustrative.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — AUTHORITY QUICK REFERENCE (FINANCIAL INTERDICTION)

Authority	Mechanism	Illustrative Application	Key Constraint
IEEPA (50 U.S.C. § 1701)	Foundational blocking authority. Active national emergency required.	All OFAC EO-based designations (EOs 13224, 13846, 14024, and program-specific orders).	Annual emergency renewal required. All downstream actions must trace to active declaration.
18 U.S.C. § 981 — Civil Forfeiture	FTO instrumentality theory. IRGC FTO designation (April 2019) supports application.	Pre-staged warrant execution. In rem vessel forfeiture in federal court.	FTO nexus must be judicially documented. Standard pipeline 45–120 days absent pre-staging.
31 U.S.C. § 5318A — Section 311	Designates foreign institution as primary money laundering concern. Severs U.S. correspondent access.	Third-country shadow banking nodes. UAE, Turkey, Hong Kong, Oman corridor institutions.	Standard designation 45–90 days. Expedited track requires documented threshold breach. APA compliance required.
EO 13224 (as amended)	Blocks property of designated FTO-linked entities and material supporters.	IRGC financial network. Crypto wallet clusters. Stablecoin freeze coordination (USDT/USDC). Note: smart-contract designation scope subject to ongoing litigation (Van Loon v. Treasury, 5th Cir. — agencies apply current case law and DOJ/OLC guidance).	Designation latency is primary gap. Stablecoin issuer protocols require pre-establishment.
EO 13846 — Iran Secondary Sanctions	Secondary sanctions on entities providing material support to Iran's petroleum, petrochemical, and financial sectors.	Chinese financial institutions facilitating NIOC purchases. Turkish trading firms. Calendared quarterly enforcement cycles.	Deterrence requires predictable, calendared enforcement. Episodic cycles are correctly assessed as tolerable risk.
CISADA § 104 (22 U.S.C. § 8513)	Mandatory sanctions on foreign financial institutions facilitating significant transactions for SDN-designated Iranian parties.	Top-5 Chinese financial institutions by NIOC transaction volume. Mandatory nature reduces discretion and strengthens credibility.	Mandatory upon positive finding. Determination packages should be maintained in readiness posture.
CAATSA §§ 231–232 (22 U.S.C. § 9241)	Mandatory sanctions for significant transactions with	Third-country institutions facilitating Russian war-economy transactions.	Mandatory provisions more credible than discretionary. State Department lead for determinations.

Authority	Mechanism	Illustrative Application	Key Constraint
	Russian defense/intelligence (§ 231) or financial (§ 232) sectors.		
EO 14024 (April 2021, as amended) — Russia	Blocks property and prohibits transactions supporting Russian government harmful activities.	Russian war-economy financial network. Third-country facilitators. Commodity intermediaries.	Confirm applicable OFAC program-specific EO before execution. Reference 'applicable IEEPA-based EO (as amended)' where specific EO cannot be sourced.
BIS Entity List (15 C.F.R. Part 744)	License requirement for all EAR-controlled items.	PRC defense-industrial firms. Dual-use technology denial. Reliability degradation targeting.	Simultaneous OFAC + BIS action eliminates 30–90 day adaptation window created by sequential action.
BIOSECURE Act (proposed — under consideration)	Would restrict federal procurement with named biotechnology companies of concern. Not operative unless enacted.	PRC biotechnology and surveillance firms (illustrative legislative pathway only).	Do not cite as enacted law. Confirm enactment status and operative provisions before any reliance.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — AUTHORITY QUICK REFERENCE (MARITIME INTERDICTION)

Authority	Mechanism	Illustrative Application	Key Constraint
14 U.S.C. § 522 — High Seas Boarding	Boarding, search, seizure of vessels subject to U.S. jurisdiction on the high seas.	Shadow fleet tanker interdiction. FTO-instrumentality vessel seizure.	Applies to: (a) stateless vessels; (b) flag state consent via MLEA; (c) FTO instrumentality designation. MIO Legal Checklist required.
Title 10 / Title 21 — Counter-Narcotics Fusion	Maritime interdiction, boarding by force, vessel seizure where narco-terrorism nexus documented.	Caribbean and Eastern Pacific corridor interdiction. Venezuela/Cuba/IRGC logistics axis.	Supports disabling fire and boarding by force. Does NOT support lethal terminal action absent imminent threat or Presidential finding under 50 U.S.C. § 3093.
50 U.S.C. § 3093 — Presidential Finding	Covert action finding. Authorizes expanded authorities beyond existing statutory frameworks.	Lethal maritime interdiction (if operationally required). Infrastructure effects operations.	Requires Presidential signature. Actions under a finding may trigger Congressional notification requirements under § 3093(c) — confirm with NSC Legal. Not self-executing from any EO.
Shadow Fleet Sanctions Act (proposed — non-operative)	Introduced legislation. Not a current source of authority.	Illustrative legislative pathway only. If enacted, would supplement existing 14 U.S.C. § 522 authority.	Do not cite as operative authority. Practitioners must confirm enactment status.

AUTHORITY GAPS REQUIRING ADDITIONAL FOUNDATIONS

Vessel confiscation (REPO-style): Current authority supports civil forfeiture under 18 U.S.C. § 981 with FTO nexus. Full confiscation and liquidation of vessel cargo requires OLC formal opinion or FY2027 NDAA statutory authority — do not rely on REPO Act alone. | Infrastructure effects: Require § 3093 Presidential finding or Title 10 military authorization with LOAC review — no EO cited here provides this independently. | Lethal maritime interdiction outside imminent threat: Requires § 3093 Presidential finding; may trigger § 3093(c) Congressional notification obligations.

III. LAYERED FRICTION ON NETWORK CONNECTIVE TISSUE

Rather than designating the principal target directly, durable maximum pressure campaigns focus cumulative friction on the profit-sensitive connective tissue that enables illicit networks to function — the brokers, exchange operators, transshipment nodes, maritime logistics providers, and professional enablers whose participation depends on a calculation that the business is worth the risk.

This approach mirrors OFAC's actual enforcement pattern in the most effective pressure campaigns. The July 2025 Iran shipping designations targeted 115+ entities across the facilitator and logistics layers, not just NIOC principals. The Russia shadow-fleet advisory series has increasingly focused on reinsurance and classification society chokepoints rather than vessel-by-vessel designation.[1] This paper formalizes that pattern into a tiered, evidence-gated sequencing model.

[1] OFAC Iran Shipping Designations, July 2025; Treasury/OFAC Shadow Fleet Advisory Series, 2024–2026. Available at ofac.treas.gov and home.treasury.gov.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — ILLUSTRATIVE TIERING STRUCTURE (ADAPT TO INSTITUTIONAL CONTEXT)

The tiering structure governs designation sequencing. Escalation is evidence-gated — Tier 3+ actions require observability metrics (Section VIII) confirming prior tier actions are producing measurable network effects. Absent confirmation, escalation defers.

Tier	Target Category	Illustrative Examples	Illustrative Cycle	Illustrative Approval
1	Individual brokers, exchange operators, VASP principals, repeat professional enablers	IRGC Quds Force financial facilitators; UAE exchange house operators; crypto mixer principals. Mirrors OFAC's July 2025 Iran designation batch structure.	Monthly — continuous	OFAC Director
2	Mid-level nodes — transshipment companies, shadow fleet operators, front-company networks	NIOC front companies; Russian shadow fleet operators; Venezuelan gold intermediaries.	Quarterly batch	SECTREAS
3	Major institutional targets — high-volume financial institutions, state-adjacent firms	Chinese banks facilitating NIOC purchases; Turkish institutions supporting Russian war-economy.	Threshold-triggered — Deputies concurrence	SECTREAS + Deputies
4	Sovereign-adjacent or systemic designations	State bank subsidiaries with direct sovereign nexus; systemic financial infrastructure.	Principals decision — stability guardrail confirmation required	Principals Committee

Trade-offs: Tighter tiering improves escalation discipline but increases coordination overhead. The evidence-gating requirement increases resource demands and classification challenges. These are deliberate costs — the alternative is premature escalation that produces sovereign-level confrontation before lower-tier pressure has been given time to work.

A. Pre-Staging to Eliminate Designation Latency

Designation latency — the 45–120 day standard pipeline from identification to enforcement action — is the primary gap allowing targeted networks to move assets and restructure before action lands. An effective pressure campaign would maintain rolling readiness packages for threshold-triggered execution rather than initiating the pipeline upon an event. This is probably the most obvious fix in the whole framework — and somehow it never gets institutionalized. The pipeline exists, so people use it. Pre-staging feels bureaucratically awkward until the first time you watch a 90-day window close around a target that moved assets on day 31.

- Warrant readiness (18 U.S.C. § 981): Rolling 90-day certification for top-50 IRGC-adjacent entities. Warrants drafted, reviewed, held for threshold-triggered execution.
- CISADA determination packages: Maintained in 90-day readiness for top-5 Chinese financial institutions by NIOC transaction volume. This mirrors existing OFAC practice for major country programs.
- CAATSA § 231/232 packages: In readiness for top-10 Russian defense-sector counterparties.
- § 311 expedited track: Documented transaction threshold breach as trigger; illustrative 10-business-day track (standard is 45–90 days).
- Crypto attribution: Standing blockchain analytics contract with short-SLA attribution capability. Stablecoin issuer coordination protocol (USDT/USDC issuers) for rapid freeze commitment upon valid OFAC designation.

B. Calendared Secondary Sanctions Enforcement

The single most impactful change from prior Iran and Russia campaigns would be replacing episodic with calendared secondary sanctions enforcement. Targets in both programs have correctly assessed episodic enforcement as tolerable risk. A published quarterly enforcement rhythm — communicated diplomatically to third-country partners — restores deterrence credibility at lower designation volume.

- Month 1 of each quarter: Tier 1 and 2 designation batch. Diplomatic pre-notification to primary third-country partners 72 hours prior.
- Month 2: Supervisory engagement with hub institutions. Compliance assessment. Remediation pathway communications.
- Month 3: Tier 2 actions where observability metrics confirm prior effects. Coalition coordination. Cycle close-out.
- Out-of-cycle Tier 3+: Threshold-triggered only. Requires Deputies or Principals concurrence and stability guardrail confirmation.

IV. RELIABILITY DEGRADATION — TARGETING SUPPLY INPUTS

The most durable constraint on illicit logistics and procurement networks is not financial designation of settlement rails but degradation of the reliability inputs that allow closed-loop systems to function and expand. Closed-loop systems can sustain volume through state subsidy or corridor diversification — but they cannot easily substitute maintenance components, classification society services, reinsurance, firmware updates, and skilled technical support.

Worth noting: this targeting approach is already reflected in 2025–2026 Treasury practice. The shadow fleet advisory series has increasingly focused on Lloyd's market coverage withdrawal and classification society engagement rather than vessel-by-vessel designation — because insurance withdrawal produces reliability degradation effects without requiring physical interdiction.[2]

[2] Treasury/OFAC Shadow Fleet Advisory Series, 2024–2026. See also Lloyd's Market Association guidance on sanctioned vessel coverage, 2025.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — RELIABILITY DEGRADATION TARGETING (ADAPT TO INSTITUTIONAL CONTEXT)

Input Category	Illustrative Enforcement Tool	Illustrative Effect
Maintenance components — maritime and aviation	BIS Entity List; Export Control Reform Act; Wassenaar allied coordination	Elevated mean time to repair; increased cannibalization; parts-to-yield deterioration
Software, firmware — dual-use systems	BIS Entity List; COINS Act provisions; BIOSECURE Act (proposed — if enacted)	System reliability degradation; version lock; security vulnerability accumulation
Classification society and maritime insurance	OFAC advisory to Lloyd's market and International Group of P&I Clubs; UK OFSI coordination	Coverage withdrawal; port access restrictions; flag registry churn; fleet expansion constraint. Mirrors current shadow-fleet advisory practice.
Reinsurance and capital backstop	OFAC SDN of reinsurance intermediaries; § 311 on capital conduit institutions	Risk concentration; reduced fleet expansion capacity
Professional formation services — SPV, trade finance	OFAC designation of repeat professional enablers; FinCEN SPV formation monitoring	Counterparty complexity; elevated formation costs; trust network fragmentation
Skilled vendor and technical support	Export control; visa restrictions; allied licensing coordination	Talent pipeline restriction; knowledge transfer limitation

Trade-offs: Reliability degradation targeting is less visible than headline designations — it does not produce press release moments. But it constrains the normalization of workaround infrastructure more durably than volume suppression. The combination of financial friction (Tier 1–2 designations) and reliability degradation (supply input targeting) is more effective than either alone.

A. Lloyd's Market and P&I Club Mechanism

The Lloyd's of London market and International Group of P&I Clubs constitute the critical chokepoint for maritime logistics reliability normalization. This mechanism has demonstrated effectiveness in prior Iran enforcement cycles. The key gap: prior unilateral OFAC advisories have not fully closed the coverage pathway for Lloyd's syndicates operating through non-U.S. members.

- A coordinated U.S.-UK advisory (OFAC and UK OFSI) closes this jurisdictional gap. The April 2025 maritime guidance moved in this direction — a formal coordinated advisory would complete the closure.
- IACS member classification societies (Lloyd's Register, Bureau Veritas, DNV, ABS) are subject to U.S. jurisdiction where they maintain U.S. operations. OFAC guidance on inspection services for designated vessels produces port access complications without interdiction.

B. Simultaneous Financial and Export Control Action

Sequential financial designation and BIS Entity List addition creates a 30–90 day adaptation window during which targets can restructure procurement before sanctions apply. The analytical fix is treating simultaneous action as the default, not an exception.

- All financial designations of entities with a procurement or technical supply nexus should be accompanied by same-day BIS Entity List addition where authority exists.
- Existing Entity List entries for Russia, Iran, DPRK, and PRC defense-industrial entities should be reviewed for cases where OFAC financial designation has not been applied — gap closure packages developed for concurrent action.

V. ESCALATION GUARDRAILS — PROTECTING MONETARY LEVERAGE

The structural failure mode in prior maximum pressure campaigns is not enforcement insufficiency. It is the combination of tactical enforcement success with gradual erosion of monetary leverage, coalition cohesion, and systemic credibility. In practice: unilateral financial shocks accelerate target adaptation AND the broader trend toward alternative settlement architectures, CIPS growth, and reduced dollar dependence in commodity corridors.

A proposed escalation guardrail index — tracking a small set of publicly available monetary and coalition indicators — would provide a rule-based rather than discretionary mechanism for pausing the most disruptive escalation actions when systemic stability indicators breach defined thresholds. The design is deliberately non-discretionary: removing the pause decision from political pressure by making it automatic upon indicator breach. One honest note: the specific threshold bands in this paper are illustrative — real operational thresholds need classified baselines that I don't have. The value is in the architecture, not the numbers.

This responds to observed data. IMF COFER Q3 2025 shows USD allocated reserves at approximately 56.92% — down from 71% in 2001. CIPS participation continues to expand. The guardrail index is designed to monitor and respond to this trend rather than ignore it.[3]

[3] IMF COFER Q3 2025; BIS Quarterly Review on payment system developments; Federal Reserve data on dollar trade finance share. These are the publicly available indicators that would anchor the guardrail index — actual operational thresholds require classified analysis.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — PROPOSED ESCALATION GUARDRAIL INDEX (ADAPT THRESHOLDS TO CLASSIFIED BASELINES)

Trigger: Two or more indicators breach defined threshold bands within a single quarter. Response: Suspend Tier 3–4 designation actions. Continue Tier 1–2 targeting. Expand multilateral coordination. Suspend unilateral financial shocks. Deputies notification within 24 hours.

Indicator	Data Source	Illustrative Threshold (Operational Thresholds Require Classified Baseline)
USD global reserve share trend	IMF COFER (public, quarterly)	Decline exceeding 1.5 percentage points in any rolling 6-month period
Non-USD settlement share in sensitive corridors	SWIFT data; bilateral reporting	Non-USD share exceeding 35% in corridor previously below 20%
Alternative settlement system participation growth (CIPS, SPFS)	Public CIPS reports; bilateral IC reporting	Institution count growth exceeding 15% quarter-over-quarter
Formal coalition divergence events	Diplomatic reporting	Three or more documented unilateral deviations within a single 90-day cycle
Energy price volatility where enforcement is a contributing factor	Brent crude; EIA; commodity analytics	Brent exceeding $120/bbl sustained 30 days with enforcement attribution
Dollar-denominated trade finance share in sanctioned corridors	BIS; ICC trade finance reports; bilateral data	Decline exceeding 20 percentage points from baseline in major commodity corridor

Deactivation: Requires two consecutive monthly reviews confirming stabilization below threshold bands. Not automatic upon indicator stabilization — deliberate design to prevent premature resumption. Joint authorization at SECTREAS level and NSC review required.

Trade-offs: The guardrail index introduces coordination overhead and creates a mechanism that sophisticated targets may attempt to manipulate by inducing indicator breach to pause enforcement. These risks are real; the index should be designed with manipulation-resistant indicator selection and an override mechanism for Principals Committee review.

VI. OBSERVABILITY METRICS — GATING ESCALATION ON EVIDENCE

In closed-loop environments where settlement data may be obscured, escalation decisions made without alternative telemetry risk compounding enforcement pressure on networks that have already adapted rather than on active pressure points. The principle is simple: Tier 3 and above actions should require evidence that prior tier actions are producing measurable effects. Absent that evidence, escalation defers.

This mirrors FATF's risk-based approach in a different context — the resource allocation logic of focusing enforcement where evidence of activity is strongest.[4]

[4] *FATF Guidance on Risk-Based Approach for the Banking Sector, 2024. Available at fatf-gafi.org.*

MODULAR PULL-OUT — COMPOSITE LOGISTICS RELIABILITY METRICS (ADAPT TO AVAILABLE DATA)

A composite logistics reliability index combining the following data streams provides the observability prerequisite for Tier 3+ escalation. Each stream is available through a combination of IC collection, commercially available maritime analytics, and bilateral partner reporting.

Data Stream	Illustrative Source	What It Measures
Satellite imaging and AIS dark event frequency	NGA; commercial providers (Planet Labs, Maxar)	Vessel position; AIS spoofing frequency; port call patterns; ship-to-ship transfer activity
Maritime behavior pattern deviation	NCIS; Office of Naval Intelligence; commercial analytics (Kpler, Vortexa)	Routing anomalies; port access changes; speed and heading deviations from baseline
Port turnaround time deltas	Commercial maritime data (Kpler, Vortexa)	Turnaround time vs. baseline — increasing delta indicates rising operational friction
Flag registry churn rate	State Department; commercial vessel tracking	Re-registration frequency; classification society change rate — indicates evasion pressure
SPV formation rates in high-risk jurisdictions	FinCEN beneficial ownership data; FATF reporting	UAE, Hong Kong, Turkey, BVI, Cayman formation rates — proxy for network reconstitution activity
Counterparty hop count in flagged corridors	NSA; FinCEN transaction monitoring	Increasing hop count = network fragmentation under Tier 1–2 pressure (positive effect indicator)

Monthly Observability Brief — required metrics for Tier 3+ escalation consideration: mean transit delay vs. baseline; node regeneration rate (% reconstituted within 90 days); corridor efficiency delta; state subsidy burden proxies; alternative settlement growth deltas; insurance coverage rate for designated vessel population.

Trade-offs: Observability protocols increase resource demands and classification burdens. Some indicators (e.g., SAR data, hop count) require IC collection commitments that may be contested. The minimum viable set for escalation gating is mean transit delay, node regeneration rate, and insurance coverage rate — these can be derived largely from commercial data.

VII. COALITION ENDURANCE — MANAGING THE POLITICAL FOUNDATION

Sustained maximum pressure campaigns require coalition durability that is actively managed rather than assumed. Allies don't fracture because they disagree ideologically — they fracture because compliance starts costing more than quiet non-participation. The remediation windows described below sound bureaucratic, and they are, but in practice that is what keeps partners at the table. The analytical requirement: compliance must provide predictable commercial benefit, and remediation pathways must be structured, transparent, and credible.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — ILLUSTRATIVE 90-DAY COALITION RHYTHM

Period	Illustrative Operational Focus
Days 0–30	Target refresh; observability metric review; target-set confirmation; pre-notification to coalition partners on upcoming actions; General License renewal review.
Days 31–60	Quiet supervisory engagement with third-country hub institutions; formal demarche delivery; remediation pathway communications; compliance assessment.
Days 61–90	Limited public enforcement actions (Tier 1 and 2); remediation monitoring; cycle close-out; DEEI/guardrail indicator review.
Out-of-cycle escalation	Permitted only upon defined trigger event. Emergency session required. Not available for Tier 3/4 absent threshold and observability confirmation.

This rhythm mirrors the enforcement cycle discipline that OFAC sanctions programs use informally. The value of formalizing it is predictability — partners can plan compliance programs around known enforcement windows, and targets lose the adaptation advantage of uncertain timing.

A. Compliance Incentive Architecture

- Fast-track licensing: Expedited General License review (illustrative: 10 business days) for firms demonstrating active compliance and restructuring to achieve it. Compliance must have a faster, cheaper pathway than evasion.
- Regulatory technical assistance: State INL Bureau technical assistance to third-country FIUs on beneficial ownership and sanctions screening. Prioritized for UAE, Turkey, Iraq, Oman — the primary hub jurisdictions.
- Structured remediation pathways: Illustrative 90-day deferred designation window with defined compliance metrics and delisting upon satisfaction. Publicly confirmable to preserve credibility.
- Enforcement framing: Communications emphasizing corrective compliance rather than condemnation. Private notification before public action where operationally and judicially possible.

B. Partner Pre-Notification Protocol

- Five Eyes Financial Intelligence: Pre-brief on pending § 311 targets and major designation sequences no later than 14 days prior. Prevents evasion through allied financial systems.
- UK OFSI: Coordinated shadow fleet vessel designation advisory and Lloyd's guidance. Joint U.S.-UK advisory closes the jurisdictional gap.
- EU (EEAS / RELEX Working Party): Synchronized quarterly designation calendars eliminate jurisdiction arbitrage between U.S. and EU enforcement cycles.
- GCC (UAE, Qatar, Bahrain): Individual bilateral engagement with 72-hour advance notice of § 311 actions in those jurisdictions. Creates compliance option; preserves relationships.
- Malacca Strait partners: Singapore and Malaysia require minimum 14-day bilateral engagement before interdiction operations within their maritime interest areas. Framing: maritime safety and MARPOL compliance — not sanctions enforcement.

C. Off-Ramp Thresholds — Verification Requirements

Credible off-ramps require defined verification mechanisms established before commitments are communicated diplomatically. The following are illustrative threshold triggers; verification mechanisms are placeholders requiring institutional definition.

- Iran: Verifiable enrichment cessation above 20% (IAEA protocol) and IRGC proxy withdrawal assessment (NIA) — illustrative trigger for 90-day SDN designation suspension and structured diplomatic window.
- Russia: Verifiable ceasefire (OSCE monitoring) and Ukrainian acknowledgment — illustrative trigger for G7-coordinated shadow fleet interdiction suspension.
- PRC facilitation networks: Documented cessation of Sinopec/Zhuhai Zhenrong Iranian crude purchases (NIA and SWIFT data) — illustrative trigger for CISADA determination suspension against compliant entities.

VIII. ILLUSTRATIVE DECISION ARCHITECTURE

The following decision authority matrix is a notional recommended architecture reflecting standard interagency practice. Practitioners adapt to their institutional authority structures, existing coordination mechanisms, and applicable delegations. One thing that stands out in coordination failures: ambiguous lead agency designation. The operative principle here is that Lead Agency designation should be exclusive — concurrent notification does not constitute approval authority.

Illustrative Action	Recommended Lead	Illustrative Approval	Concurrent Notification
SDN — Tier 1/2 (criminal, facilitator)	Treasury/OFAC	OFAC Director	State, NSC, DOJ, IC
SDN — Tier 3 (major institutional)	Treasury/OFAC	SECTREAS	Deputies notification
SDN — Tier 4 (sovereign-adjacent)	Treasury/OFAC	SECTREAS + NSC	Principals Committee
§ 311 Designation	Treasury/FinCEN	SECTREAS + NSC concurrence	State, DOJ, IC, relevant COCOM
CISADA § 104 Determination	Treasury/OFAC + State (joint)	SECTREAS + SECSTATE	NSC, Commerce, USTR, IC
CAATSA §§ 231/232 Determination	State (regional bureau)	SECSTATE	Treasury, NSC, Commerce
18 U.S.C. § 981 Warrant Execution	DOJ/AFMLS	AG or DAG	Treasury/OFAC, State, NSC
Crypto Wallet Freeze	Treasury/OFAC Cyber	OFAC Director	DOJ Cyber, FBI, NSC
High Seas Boarding — Shadow Fleet	Navy/USCG (INDO-PACOM)	SECDEF (pre-authorized standing orders)	State, Treasury, NSC
In Rem Vessel Forfeiture Filing	DOJ Civil + AFMLS	AG + district court	Treasury, State, DoD
BIS Entity List Addition	Commerce/BIS	Commerce Secretary	USTR, Treasury, State, DoD OUSD(A&S)
Caribbean Interdiction — Non-lethal	SOUTHCOM/ JIATF-South	SECDEF (standing Title 10)	State, Treasury, NSC
Lethal Maritime Interdiction	SOUTHCOM Commander	POTUS — § 3093 finding required; § 3093(c) notification may apply	SECDEF, NSC — no action absent finding
Guardrail Downshift Activation	Treasury/OFAC + NSC (joint)	SECTREAS + National Security Advisor (notional)	All principals — automatic notification

Illustrative Coordination Cadence

Cadence	Scope
Weekly — active cycles	Target refresh; observability metric review; designation pipeline; deconfliction.
Bi-weekly — maintenance	Guardrail indicator review; coalition partner status; pre-coordination on upcoming actions.

Cadence	Scope
Monthly	Guardrail formal assessment; observability brief review; metric update.
Quarterly	Coalition partner coordination; cycle close-out; next-cycle target set approval.
Deputies — trigger-based	Guardrail downshift; escalation trigger events; major judicial challenge.
Principals — trigger-based	§ 3093 finding requests; actions beyond established ROE; major-power military signaling.

IX. PRACTITIONER CHECKLIST — 10 ELEMENTS YOU COULD ADAPT TODAY

This checklist distills the framework into the ten highest-impact elements. Each is modular — adaptable independently of the others. None requires the full framework to be operationally useful.

MODULAR PULL-OUT — PRACTITIONER CHECKLIST (EXTRACT, ADAPT, OPERATIONALIZE)

#	Element	What It Addresses	Illustrative Basis
1	Pre-staged designation packages — 90-day readiness certification for top-tier targets	Eliminates 45–120 day designation latency. Enables threshold-triggered execution rather than post-event initiation. (Also worth adding: OLC opinion on § 981(a)(1)(G) vessel confiscation applicability and FY2027 NDAA authority placeholder — add if your program needs it.)	18 U.S.C. § 981; CISADA § 104; CAATSA §§ 231–232
2	Simultaneous OFAC + BIS action protocol	Eliminates 30–90 day adaptation window created by sequential financial and export control action.	15 C.F.R. Part 744; applicable OFAC EO program
3	Calendared quarterly secondary sanctions enforcement cycles	Replaces episodic enforcement that targets correctly assess as tolerable risk. Restores deterrence credibility.	EO 13846; CAATSA; CISADA
4	Coordinated U.S.-UK OFAC/OFSI advisory on shadow fleet insurance	Closes jurisdictional gap in Lloyd's market coverage that unilateral U.S. advisories have not closed. Reliability degradation without interdiction.	EO 13224; EO 13846
5	Evidence-gated escalation — observability metrics as Tier 3+ prerequisite	Prevents escalation to major institutional actions before lower-tier pressure has produced measurable effects.	Applicable policy guidance (notional)
6	Proposed escalation guardrail index — six monetary and coalition indicators	Rule-based, non-discretionary mechanism to pause Tier 3–4 actions when systemic stability indicators breach thresholds.	IMF COFER; SWIFT data; diplomatic reporting
7	Rapid Response Crypto Interdiction posture — short-SLA blockchain analytics and stablecoin issuer protocol	Closes 24–72 hour gap between wallet cluster identification and freeze action.	EO 13224 (as amended); Van Loon, 5th Cir. — agencies apply current DOJ/OLC guidance
8	Tiered partner pre-notification — 72 hours for GCC; 14 days for § 311 targets; 14 days for Malacca Strait operations	Prevents evasion through allied systems. Creates compliance option. Preserves bilateral relationships.	State / FVEY frameworks
9	Structured remediation pathways — 90-day deferred designation window with defined compliance metrics	Makes compliance commercially rational. Reduces coalition fracture risk. Builds enforcement credibility through transparent process.	OFAC GL framework; applicable APA procedures
10	(See note in item 1 above)	—	—

X. ILLUSTRATIVE TARGET-SPECIFIC PARAMETERS

All parameters are analytical illustrations — not findings, determinations, or enforcement recommendations. Any actual enforcement action requires independent evidentiary sufficiency, agency legal review, and formal authorization. These sections are designed to be extracted individually; each target track is self-contained.

A. Iran — IRGC and NIOC-Linked Networks

Track	Illustrative Parameters
Financial	Monthly Tier 1 SDN batches targeting IRGC Quds Force facilitator network. Priority: oil revenue flows through Iraqi, UAE, and Omani front companies — mirroring the target typology of OFAC's July 2025 designation package. CISADA § 104 determination packages for top-5 Chinese purchasers maintained in 90-day readiness. EO 13224; EO 13846; CISADA § 104.
Maritime	NIOC-chartered tanker FTO instrumentality designation packages pre-positioned alongside INDO-PACOM boarding packages. Lloyd's advisory coordinated with UK OFSI. Illustrative timeline: designation packages at 30 days; boarding packages at 60 days; first interdiction at 90 days to establish operational credibility. Basis: 18 U.S.C. § 981; 14 U.S.C. § 522.
Diplomatic	Formal demarches to Beijing specifying Sinopec and Zhuhai Zhenrong NIOC purchase volumes, applicable CISADA threshold, and illustrative 45-day compliance window with specific SDN triggers. Coordinated EU/UK autonomous sanctions synchronization.
Crypto	IRGC wallet cluster attribution. OFAC designation batch. Stablecoin issuer coordination. Note: smart-contract designation scope subject to ongoing litigation (Van Loon v. Treasury, 5th Cir.); agencies apply current case law and DOJ/OLC guidance. Basis: EO 13224 (as amended).

B. Russia — Shadow Fleet and War-Economy Finance

Track	Illustrative Parameters
Maritime	In rem forfeiture actions in SDNY for top-3 documented shadow fleet vessels with FTO nexus. Simultaneous Lloyd's advisory. Precedent-building litigation track running in parallel with FY2027 NDAA legislative authority expansion effort. Basis: 18 U.S.C. § 981(a)(1)(G).
Financial	CAATSA § 232 determination packages for top-10 third-country financial institutions by Russian sanctioned-entity transaction volume. § 311 designation packages for Turkish and UAE institutions facilitating war-economy transactions. G7 synchronized designation calendar to eliminate timing gap arbitrage. Basis: CAATSA §§ 231–232; EO 14024; 31 U.S.C. § 5318A.
Commodity	Updated OFAC guidance confirming that U.S. person involvement in any intermediary step — insurance, financing, legal services — for Russian-origin commodity transactions requires OFAC authorization regardless of transaction jurisdiction.
Coalition	State EUR Bureau coordination with EU RELEX Working Party on synchronized quarterly designation batches. Russian evasion architecture exploits timing gaps between U.S. and EU enforcement cycles — synchronized calendars eliminate this.

C. PRC-Linked Networks — Selective Targeting

ESCALATION RISK — CHINA

Targeting scope is analytically bounded to entities facilitating Iranian/Russian sanctions evasion, BIOSECURE/COINS Act-covered firms, and controlled technology acquisition. Broader sovereign-level pressure requires separate Principals-level decision. Any Tier 3 or Tier 4 action against PRC-headquartered institutions requires Principals Committee awareness and a pre-developed escalation response framework before execution. A PRC escalation threshold framework communicated to Beijing through diplomatic channels establishes deterrence clarity and reduces miscalculation risk.

Track	Illustrative Parameters
Export Control	BIS Entity List additions for applicable NDAA-identified firms. DoD OUSD(A&S) procurement exclusion actions. Note: BIOSECURE Act cited as proposed/under consideration — practitioners must confirm enacted text before reliance. Basis: 15 C.F.R. Part 744; applicable enacted NDAA provisions.
Secondary Sanctions	CISADA and EO 13846 determination packages in 90-day readiness against top-5 Chinese NIOC purchasers. Preceded by formal demarche with illustrative 45-day compliance window. Tier 3 approval required.
Escalation Management	NSC preparation of PRC escalation threshold framework and diplomatic communication before any Tier 3+ action.

D. Cuba — GAESA Network | E. Venezuela — Petroleum, Gold, Narco-Trafficking

Target	Track	Illustrative Parameters
Cuba	Financial	GAESA network mapping identifying second-order hard currency access entities. SDN designation batch targeting non-previously-designated subsidiaries. Basis: EO 13850.
Cuba	Maritime	Venezuelan tanker interdiction targeting Cuba-bound petroleum deliveries. SOUTHCOM/JIATF-South coordination. Basis: Title 10/Title 21 fusion; EO 13850.
Cuba	Diplomatic	State WHA Bureau coalition-building within OAS and CELAC. EU autonomous sanctions coordination. Caribbean partner engagement preceding public actions.
Venezuela	Petroleum	OFAC compliance review of all active Venezuela General Licenses. Revocation or conditioning where beneficiary entities have documented IRGC or Russian GRU nexus. Basis: EO 13850.
Venezuela	Gold	OFAC designation of UAE-based intermediaries facilitating Venezuelan gold purchases. State NEA bilateral notification 72 hours prior to designation. Basis: EO 13850.
Venezuela	Narco-Terrorism	JIATF-South prosecution targeting against Cartel de Los Soles under NDAA narco-terrorism authorities. DOJ SDNY active grand jury. Basis: Title 10/Title 21; Foreign Narcotics Kingpin Designation Act.

XI. SCOPE — WHAT THIS PAPER DOES AND DOES NOT DO

This Paper Does	This Paper Does Not
Synthesize 2025–2026 enforcement patterns into a notional coordination model	Direct, recommend, or request action by any U.S. government agency
Map existing public statutory authorities with their operative mechanisms and constraints	Constitute legal advice, policy guidance, or operational instruction
Identify execution gaps and structural failure modes in prior campaigns	Represent official policy, classified guidance, or government endorsement
Provide modular analytical components for institutional adaptation and drafting	Expand, create, or modify any legal authority
Illustrate what legally defensible, evidence-gated execution could look like	Authorize, initiate, or direct any enforcement action
Reduce practitioner drafting burden by performing analytical labor in advance	Claim to guarantee dismantlement of a peer economy or nuclear program
Flag authority gaps and legal exposure risks prominently	Use invented doctrine names as substitutes for describing real coordination logic
State bounded, calibrated claims about achievable outcomes	Request approval, claim institutional access, or imply classified support

SCOPE CLARIFICATION

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CONCLUSION

This paper illustrates what a decision-ready coordinated maximum pressure execution framework could look like, grounded in 2025–2026 enforcement practice and existing statutory authorities. Success is defined as preserved leverage and controlled degradation of illicit network efficiency over 24–60 months — not regime collapse or decisive coercive breakthrough.

The core contribution is structural: converting episodic, reactive designation cycles into a governed, observable, evidence-gated enforcement system. The escalation guardrails prevent the structural failure mode that has characterized prior campaigns. The layered friction approach on network connective tissue is more durable than headline designations of principal targets. The reliability degradation targeting constrains the normalization of workaround infrastructure in ways that volume suppression cannot.

Each section is modular. Take what reduces your drafting burden. Adapt what requires institutional tailoring. Discard what does not fit your operational context. That's what I have — hope a piece of it proves useful. Happy to be told where I got it wrong.

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